

In spite of this, Laos remained divided by factions determined to continue the battle for power. The North Vietnamese needed to control the eastern corridor that formed an integral part of the Ho Chi Minh Trail. Meanwhile, the US was determined to block the North Vietnamese incursions.

It was a task Kennedy gave to the CIA, which had already set its own secret plan in motion. Operation Momentum, as it was codenamed, recruited a Hmong guerrilla army—the *Armée Clandestine*—to fight for the CIA by proxy. It was soon a match for the Pathet Lao. By the end of 1963, around 20,000 Hmong had been recruited. The “Secret War,” which lasted for more than 13 years, was the largest paramilitary operation the CIA had ever undertaken.

■ **9,000** Number of hill tribesmen in the CIA's *Armée Clandestine* by summer 1961.



Secret soldiers

These Hmong guerrillas in Laos' “Secret War” are armed with weapons dropped by Air America, the CIA's clandestine airline. The guerrillas were trained by Special Forces advisers and Thai Police Aerial Reinforcement Unit teams.

“The **security of all Southeast Asia** will be **endangered** if Laos loses its **neutral independence.**”

PRESIDENT JOHN F. KENNEDY, TELEVISION ADDRESS TO THE NATION, MARCH 23, 1961